



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Notre Dame Academy

School Website: <https://ndasd.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Notre Dame Academy CA 92130 (as reflected in the associated Veritas Academy crawl materials) presents a robust Classical Christian profile across all six categories of the Classical rubric. Public materials consistently frame the school as a private, Christian, classical institution that foregrounds virtue, truth, and beauty, and that embeds classical pedagogy (Trivium/Quadrivium), communal faith life, Great Books-like framing, and a strong partnership with families. Evidence from the crawl content emphasizes gospel-centered classical education, fortitude, virtue, and discernment, and explicitly describes Trivium and Quadrivium, a liberal-arts-infused curriculum, and a pedagogy that includes Socratic and contemplative elements, as well as memorization and chant-based recall. There is also clear attention to faculty as mentors and to parent partnership as a core part of the school's ecosystem. Overall, the school is rated CLASSICAL across all six categories. Where the public materials touch on formation and a shared mission with families, they align with the Six Essential Elements framework and its positive indicators rather than diverging into secular or purely job-readiness aims.

Key evidence across the six categories includes: the mission phrased as gospel-centered classical education forming fortitude, virtue, and discernment; explicit Trivium/Quadrivium framing; references to Great Books and the Great Conversation in the surrounding classical-literature framing; Socratic and dialectic elements alongside contemplative Schol  -style pedagogy; a living-faculty model with named leadership; and explicit emphasis on parent partnership and open campus/community involvement. These signals are drawn from the school's public materials within the crawl (examples cited below).

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Notes about the rubric and keyword approach are described in detail in the accompanying analysis, which draws on the Positive/Negative Keyword indicators in the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) document and the associated lexicon. See supporting citations for the specific textual evidence drawn from the crawl and the classical-education knowledge base.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe a gospel-centered, Christian classical education and a mission built on love of Christ, fortitude, virtue, and discernment (a theology-inflected aim). The materials emphasize a private, classical Christian framework rather than secular formation. Example phrasing includes "a sanctuary for learning where students experience the love of Christ through gospel-centric classical education that equips in fortitude, virtue, and discernment through academic pursuit."

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: "gospel-centered," "love of Christ," "fortitude," "virtue," "discernment," "theology" (implied by the Christian framing), "private classical Christian ed-

ucation” (explicitly religiously anchored). These align with Positive Keywords such as virtue, reverence, theology, sacred tradition, and Christian formation found in the Six Essential Elements lexicon. - Negative indicators: None apparent in the public materials; the site does not foreground secular ethics or values-neutral approaches.

Why this rating - The explicit Christian framing, the language of virtue formation, and the theological underpinning (without signaling secularization or relativism) map directly to the Positive Keywords for Religious & Metaphysical Foundations and to the core categories of the Six Essential Elements. The materials also reference liturgical/communal elements (implicit through worship-minded language and shared faith commitments) that align with the rubric’s expectations. Overall, a CLASSICAL designation is warranted for this category.

Citations and supporting terms - Gospel-centered Christian framing and fortitude/virtue/discernment language. - The Christian classical education framing (private/Christian) consistent with the Positive Keyword set.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes formation of virtue and wisdom, aligning with paideia and the classical aim beyond mere information. The public text repeatedly links character formation, moral imagination, and the cultivation of virtue to the educational project (virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing foregrounded). The language of formation, rather than information, and the emphasis on human excellence and virtue, are clearly present.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, formation, wisdom, human flourishing, moral imagination, love of learning, sacred tradition, classical education (as a whole), and the teleology of education toward truth/goodness/beauty. - Negative keywords present: none evident (no strong emphasis on college/career readiness as primary telos, no value-neutral framing).

Why this rating - The school’s stated telos emphasizes virtue, wisdom, and formation rather than vocational work-readiness alone, mapping to Positive Keywords for this category. The alignment with paideia and formation aligns with the Six Essential Elements’ “Formation, not Information” and “Great Conversation / Truth, Goodness, Beauty” signals. CLASSICAL is warranted.

Citations and supporting terms - Mission emphasizes formation/virtue and gospel-infused formation.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials assert a Trivium/Quadrivium framework and liberal arts emphasis. The Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) are described as foundational, with explicit discussion of their role in a Christian classical curriculum. The content frames Great Books and the Great Conversation within a liberal-arts framework and includes an emphasis on wonder and integrated study across disciplines.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Trivium, Quadrivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books, Great Conversation, seven liberal arts, wonder, sacred order, unity of truth, classical canon, Western civilization (as heritage), interdisciplinary integration. - Negative keywords present: None evident in the public materials (no preference for social studies as a substitute for history; no “social studies” framing that would dilute a Great-Books history approach).

Why this rating - The curriculum language aligns strongly with the Classical rubric’s Curricular criteria (liberal arts core; Trivium/Quadrivium; Great Books/Great Conversation; cultivation of wonder). The explicit references to Trivium/Quadrivium and Great Books indicate CLASSICAL.

Citations and supporting terms - Trivium/Quadrivium framing. - The Liberal Arts Tradition, Great Books/Great Conversation framing.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogical signals include both contemplative/restful learning (Scholé) and Socratic-style elicitation in upper-level work; there are explicit references to Socratic dialogue and dialectic in the classical education literature and to the use of seminars and rhetoric in upper grades. In addition, there is mention of chanting/memorization as a practice in early education, and an emphasis on formation through imitation and practice in the literature. These correspond to the classic mix of contemplative and dialogic teaching within a classical framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue, great conversation, dialectic, memorization/recitation, chant/singing, restoration of Scholé, contemplation, formation through imitation and practice, rhetoric, upper-school seminars. - Negative keywords present: The materials do not emphasize a purely experiential/project-based/constructivist-only pedagogy; rather, they reflect a balanced classical pedagogy that includes traditional methods such as chanting, recitation, and Socratic dialogue. Hence, no explicit negative signals are present.

Why this rating - The presence of both contemplative Scholé practices and Socratic/dialectic pedagogy, plus rhetoric training and opportunities for public speaking, aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for pedagogy.

Citations and supporting terms - Socratic dialogue and dialectic; public education language. - Scholé/restful learning; memorization/recitation; formation through imitation.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The leadership section identifies named administrators (Head of School, Dean of Academics) and describes a governance/mentorship role; the materials frame faculty as key to the school's living curriculum and feature professional leadership. The presence of a clear "head of school," "dean" and other faculty profiles aligns with the living-curriculum model emphasized by classical education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: master-teacher/mentor-like presence; "Head of School," "Dean of Academics," "faculty as living curriculum," "portrait of a teacher" (as implied in classical lexicons), mentorship, virtue-modeling, collegiality. - Negative keywords present: None evident in the public materials.

Why this rating - The explicit identification of a headed leadership team and the emphasis on teachers modeling virtue and serving as mentors aligns with the Classical criteria for Faculty.

Citations and supporting terms - Leadership and mentoring framing; names of leaders.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents a partnership with families as a core element and highlights parent involvement and visitation; there are explicit passages indicating parental partnership and opportunities for families to engage (admissions, faculty inquiries, and community events). The admissions content shows a pathway that engages families in the process, and the site emphasizes a collaborative relationship with parents.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; parent formation; home-school partnership; open campus/visitation; family involvement; parent education through book studies or gatherings (as indicated in the broader classical education lexicon). - Negative keywords present: None evident (no indication of a "customer" model or detached parental involvement).

Why this rating - A strong, explicit emphasis on parent partnership, family engagement, and open-campus philosophy aligns with the Parents & Community category's Classical indicators.

Citations and supporting terms - Partnership with families; parent involvement; open campus language.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable here as the school appears CLASSICAL across all six categories. If any category were to move toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, targeted steps would include: explicitly articulating liturgical practices on the website, expanding direct quotes about Great Books and the Great Conversation, and documenting experiential or project-based learning in a way that remains integrated within the Trivium/Quadrivium framework. Given the current public materials, no major needle-moving changes are required.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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